Dad Needs Help and Everyone Is Asking: The First Three Things to Write Down

Three notes, in order, and what to leave for later.

Something happened with Dad, and your phone has been busy ever since: your sister, the neighbor, a nurse whose name you didn't catch. Each of them needs the story, and each time you tell it from memory.

Begin with a pen. Three things to write down, in this order.

1 Write down what happened

In a few plain lines, record the event or change that started all this: what happened, the day, and who was there. If you heard part of it from someone else, write who told you.

WHY THIS COMES FIRST It's the first thing every caller asks, and a written version stays the same from one telling to the next.

2 List the decisions coming up, with any dates

Write each decision someone has told you is coming, who said so, and any date they gave, even if you're not sure the date is firm. If Dad is in a hospital or another care setting, Medicare's discharge checklist suggests writing down the names and phone numbers of the people to call with questions, and the dates and times of upcoming appointments. The Family Caregiver Alliance adds: know who your go-to person is for care questions. [1] [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Once the next decision has a name, the family can talk about one thing at a time.

3 Name one family contact, and a backup

Agree on one person who takes the calls and passes on the news for now, and a second person for when the first can't be reached. Put both names and numbers at the top of the page, and under them list who needs to hear where things stand today. AARP's planning guide for families calls this role a point person: someone who keeps the process moving and makes sure people understand what's been decided. [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Everyone then knows whose phone to ring, and nobody has to wonder whether a message was passed along.

What to leave for later

- A full account of Dad's day, morning to overnight. It comes next, and it goes faster once these three notes exist.
- Who in the family does which task from here on.
- The points where relatives remember things differently. Write both versions down and move on.
- What the answer to the decision should be. That takes a fuller picture than three notes, and the people who assess Dad.

> **What doesn't go on a list**
>
> A question about Dad's health or his treatment goes to his doctor or nurse, not onto this page. An emergency goes to emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't interpret anything you were told, and it doesn't decide anything about Dad's care. It gets the first three notes onto one page.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down what happened, the decisions coming up and who the family contact is. The care interview takes it from there: it walks you through the rest of Dad's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Writing down the people to call and the dates of appointments follows Medicare's discharge checklist and the Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide, which apply when Dad is in a hospital or another care setting. “Point person” is AARP's term. The three notes, their order and the backup contact are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. Medicare (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Your discharge planning checklist
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
3. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.